

have some aspect of the 'grind' to them at their core, be it climbing the ranked ladder or continuously 'farming' mobs for drops or levels. In a multiplayer game you need something to do or you're stuck, and no one likes being stuck. Just take the super popular Pokemon Go for instance, this game is all about the grind. You need to grind to level up your pokemon, you need to grind to actually be able to even start challenging gyms, and you need to keep grinding to keep those CP levels high. A lot of

people might not have had the time or interest to actually do the grind to get to level 5 and access the fun stuff, so you're losing out on potential players there.

That's another reason people might not want to go through with the grind. It's a time consuming thing, it takes a certain amount of dedication and time on your part. And very often that's something people can't afford to give, especially more so if the game itself is sub-par and has poor mechanics.

The Good Grind

So what entails good grinding then? Is it even a good thing considering all of the aforementioned things? Good grinding is when you don't even realise that you're actually going through with the grind. You're spending hours in the game, having a good time, and you don't even realise that you've probably been grinding for God knows how long. The key factor here is that the game itself is enjoyable and has good mechanics. But those aren't the only things that come into play, several factors within a game actually contribute to having an enjoyable grind. The world of the game itself, the graphics or aesthetics of the game, and even the characters in the game, all play an important role. In fact, there's even a psychological angle to it: validation, reason, cause, whatever you want to call it. It's no longer mindless grinding anymore, the world you're in needs you, and therefore you want to be at your best for that world. You feel like you're a part of this fictional world, and your contribution and participation actually affects and shapes the world

around you. You've developed a kind of attachment to your character and the people you've met. Sure they're fictional but you still don't want to let them down. If you've played many RPGs and JRPGs (the good ones anyway) then you know what we're talking about, that level of immersion actually leaves you with a sense of responsibility to the game and its world, motivating you to want to do your best. And if a game has left you with this feeling in the past, then that game is doing it right!

This is different from a game that NEEDS you to level up to access the next level. You don't have an option here, you have to go through with it if you want to proceed. The difference here is that the game is asking you to grind; in a good game, you actually want to grind. Let's use Borderlands 2 as an example, most of us have played this gem, and we all know that you don't really have to grind too much at all to finish this game. But the world, goofy and relatable characters, interesting story, the mechanics, it's all amazing. You feel a sense of attachment to the characters and the world, and you decide to yourself, "yeah, I actually want to help these folk deal with that scumbag Handsome Jack."

This feeling carries over to multiplayer quite nicely, only this time it's real people, not fictional ones. You don't want to be a burden to your team, even if you're not a very good player, you definitely don't want to feel useless. Of course there's the bragging rights as well, you want to have that amazing gear or that really high ranking badge to be able to brag to

your friends about them. And on a deeper more philosophical note, unless you're a total ass, you probably want to help or assist the people you're playing with.

Conclusion

There's more to grinding than meets the eye. While in the real world we're powerless and have no control, inside a video game you feel like you can make a difference, even if it's a tiny one. Even in an MMORPG where you may spend hours alone, grinding for higher levels and better gear, when the time comes for group raids and world bosses, you're contributing, and the amount of effort you put in grinding actually shows, and to many people this feeling matters, a lot. So in conclusion, there's two reasons for someone to grind in a video game. The first one is because the game sucks, and the grinding is meant to be a scapegoat to make it look like there's more to it. If you ever come across games like that, just skip them, they don't deserve your attention. The second reason is when you want to be the very best like no one ever was. The game matters enough to you that you've decided to give it your all.

Grinding is not going away anytime soon, it's an integral part of gaming, as long as there are games in which there's experience points to gain, there is going to be grinding. And when you find a game where you don't even realise the number of hours you've sunk in, then you've successfully enjoyed a good grind, and probably on a really good game. *



According to a survey by the Entertainment Software Association, gamers spend an average of about 6.5 hours per week playing multiplayer games online.